	India	UK	USA	China
Highway Length (km)	146,000	3,700	*78,680	190,700
No. of Rest Areas	94	107	1,840	5,800
Average Spacing (km)	1553.2	34.6	42.8	32.9

*Interstate only

Sources: Federal Highway Administration, USA; Department for Transport, UK; NDRC and MoT annual reports and highway statistics, China



line with international standards: the United States (every 43 km), the United Kingdom (35 km) and China (33 km).

The new policy, a draft version of which has been circulated for shareholder views, details a template for WSAs to be opened on private land, which will help them achieve an eventual target of 5,000 WSAs, 700 by 2030. The government also aims to exert tighter control, enforced via the National Highways Logistics Management Ltd (NHLML) and also share some of the financial burden. Earlier attempts by the government, with a variety of incentives given to oil companies and F&B operators, failed due to low investor interest, dodgy traffic projections, competition from local facilities and the bureaucratic nightmare of bids and delayed clearances. Landmark attempts include a government policy in 2021 that translated to a risky investment of Rs 5-10 crore per site from the private sector without guarantees of footfall or revenue, and last year's Humsafar policy that aimed to standardise existing and upcoming facilities under the purview of MoRTH, but failed to take off due to little interest and enforcement. The government is now making a renewed effort after taking each of these into consideration.

A NEW APPROACH

Here's how the policy might work. The draft document says that if you have land, you can open a WSA and run it as a franchise of the NHLML. Or you can lease it to the body, which will bid it out to operators. The franchise fee of Rs 100 a month for the first three years and Rs 25,000 thereafter (paid to NHLML) will be indexed annually. If you meet affordability and quality metrics for the truckers' facility, you get a 25 per cent discount. Revenue must be within tight bounds: high markups for profit are not allowed.

"Unfortunately, there's a misconception that everything must generate revenue," says Nitin Gadkari, Union minister of road transport and highways. "We have a duty to provide quality services—clean toilets, restaurants, rest areas and access to local handicrafts and produce. But this social angle is often lost in the tender process. They are floated, responses are poor, some companies back out. This mindset has to change...."



NITIN GADKARI
Union Minister of Road Transport and Highways

"WE'RE REVIEWING POLICIES. SOME DEVELOPERS CLAIM PROJECTED TRAFFIC HASN'T MATERIALISED. THAT'S A SEPARATE ISSUE BUT WE MUST KEEP TRYING TO IMPROVE"

The government also hopes for realtime feedback from consumers. For instance, it's mandatory for WSAs to be listed on RajmargYatra, an NHAI app where upkeep targets—for toilets, lighting, fuelling stations and sanitation—will be published regularly. The app will have provision for user ratings to help discerning travellers.

There are other requirements as well. WSAs must be on a national highway or within a kilometre of an access point, the landowner must have a clear title, the plot lease will be for 30 years, 60 per cent of the site must have free parking. Apart from the usual facilities, a first-aid facility, baby-care room, driver dorm, children's play space